Activity 3 — Diagnosing Customer Needs at a Growing SME — TechNova Account Review

Topic	3 — Identifying and Addressing Customer Needs
Mapping	LO1 · Identify functional and emotional needs, and map them to the four levels of addressing needs.
Format	Case Study + Role Play
Duration	25 minutes
Roles	Pairs. Role A = TechNova Account Manager, Role B = Daniel Lim. Observer optional.

The Scenario

TechNova Solutions (Singapore) supplies a cloud project-management platform. Mr Daniel Lim is Operations Director at Horizon Builders Pte Ltd, a Woodlands-based construction firm and a customer for 6 years. Horizon has grown from 12 to 50 employees. Daniel emails: 'Uploads are painfully slow, the reports are useless for what we need, and it took your support team 4 days to answer my last ticket. Competitors are offering us more for less. I need to justify this renewal to my MD by end of month.'

What the account record shows: Horizon is on Team Pro (a 15-seat plan) with 50 users sharing logins. Upload slowness correlates with 200MB+ site photo batches — the plan caps concurrent uploads. The reporting Daniel wants (cost-per-project roll-up) exists in the Enterprise tier. The 4-day ticket was logged during the Chinese New Year holiday period. Daniel has never had a formal account review in 6 years.

What You Will Produce

A needs analysis separating stated complaints from root needs, mapped to the four levels of addressing needs.

Materials: Needs analysis worksheet · Four-levels template.

Discussion Questions

1. Separate what Daniel SAID from what Daniel NEEDS. Write two columns. They are not the same list.
2. Identify Daniel's FUNCTIONAL needs and his EMOTIONAL needs. Which one is driving the email's tone?
3. 'I need to justify this renewal to my MD by end of month.' What does this sentence tell you that the complaints do not?

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4. Map your findings to the four levels: understand the problem / meet basic needs / think outside the box / go the extra mile. What sits at each level?

5. Horizon has 50 users on a 15-seat plan. This is a contract breach AND the cause of the slowness. How do you raise it without turning a save into a fight?

6. Six years, no account review. What does that reveal about TechNova's own service process — and what should change?

Step-by-Step

1. Read the case individually. Underline every sentence where Daniel states a problem, and circle every sentence that tells you about his SITUATION rather than his complaint.

2. Draw two columns on your worksheet: WHAT HE SAID and WHAT HE NEEDS. Fill the left column first — it is quick, it is just his words. The right column takes longer because it requires inference.

3. Under WHAT HE NEEDS, tag each item F (functional) or E (emotional). If you have no E items, you have not finished — re-read the last sentence of his email.

4. On the four-levels template, place each need at the correct level. Level 1 (understand the problem) must be filled before you write anything at Level 2 — resist jumping to solutions.

5. Prepare five OPEN questions for the discovery call. Open questions start with what, how, tell me, walk me through. If a question can be answered yes/no, rewrite it.

6. Assign roles: A = Account Manager, B = Daniel Lim. B, you are frustrated but not abusive — you want to stay if given a reason.

7. Run a 6-minute discovery call. A opens by acknowledging the 6-year relationship, then asks the open questions and PARAPHRASES each answer back before moving to the next.

8. A must NOT propose an upgrade in the first 4 minutes. Diagnose before you prescribe — a plan upsell offered too early reads as a sales pitch and confirms Daniel's suspicion.

9. In the last 2 minutes, A summarises the needs back to Daniel and proposes one action at each of the four levels, ending with the extra-mile offer to build the MD's report.

10. Debrief: B rates whether A understood the real brief (the MD deadline) or only fixed the three complaints.

Debrief — What a Strong Answer Looks Like

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- Said vs needed: he SAYS slow uploads, useless reports, slow support. He NEEDS a defensible business case for his MD by month end. Solve only the first three and you still lose the account.
- The emotional need is dominant: Daniel is exposed in front of his MD. The functional fixes are the evidence he needs to not look foolish for having stayed 6 years.
- The last sentence is the actual brief. Everything before it is symptoms. Learners who spot this are doing genuine needs identification rather than complaint triage.
- Four levels — understand: the plan no longer fits a 50-person firm. Basic: fix the upload cap and the ticket SLA. Outside the box: the seat overage is leverage for a migration, not a penalty. Extra mile: build the cost-per-project report FOR his MD deck.
- The 15-seat breach must be raised as a discovery, not an accusation: 'your growth has outrun the plan we sold you six years ago — that's on us for not reviewing it.'
- The real service failure is TechNova's: no account review in 6 years means nobody was listening until the customer shouted. The process fix is a scheduled review cadence — this is a Topic 7 closed-loop point arriving early.

Check Your Work

Your needs analysis has at least one emotional need identified, all four levels populated, and your role-play partner confirms you surfaced the MD deadline as the real brief.

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